Now imagine that you receive a new file called partygoers.txt containing the attendee list every time it changes and that you have access to this file. You already have a way to fetch the attendee count from a web browser, but how do you write a web server that serves up the attendee count by reading it from a file? Reading a file in Node.js looks a lot like the Ajax you just wrote:

```
fs = require 'fs'

readAttendeesList = (error, fileContents) ->
  console.log fileContents

fs.readFile 'partygoers.txt', readAttendeesList
```

Require the Node.js filesystem module fs.

Invoke fs.readFile with the file to read and a callback function to be invoked when it's done.

Great, now you can read the attendee file. The next step will be to serve the attendee count on the web somewhere so that the website can fetch it using Ajax. Before moving on, though, you might want to spend some time experimenting with file reading to become comfortable with it. Writing a version of a small utility called `cat` will help you do that.

A cat program

In the following listing is a simple program that's similar to the `cat` utility found on Unix-like operating systems. This program prints the contents of a file.

Listing 3.3. Cat utility

```
fs = require 'fs'

file = process.argv[2]
fs.readFile file, 'utf-8', (error, contents) ->
  if error
    console.log error
  else
    console.log contents
```

The readFile call needs to know what encoding the file has; use utf-8.

If there's an error reading the file, just console.log the error.

console.log the file if no error.

Ready to continue and serve a web page using Node.js? Ready for the surprise (or not)? Serving a website involves callback functions.

3.3.3. Event-driven file serving with Node.js